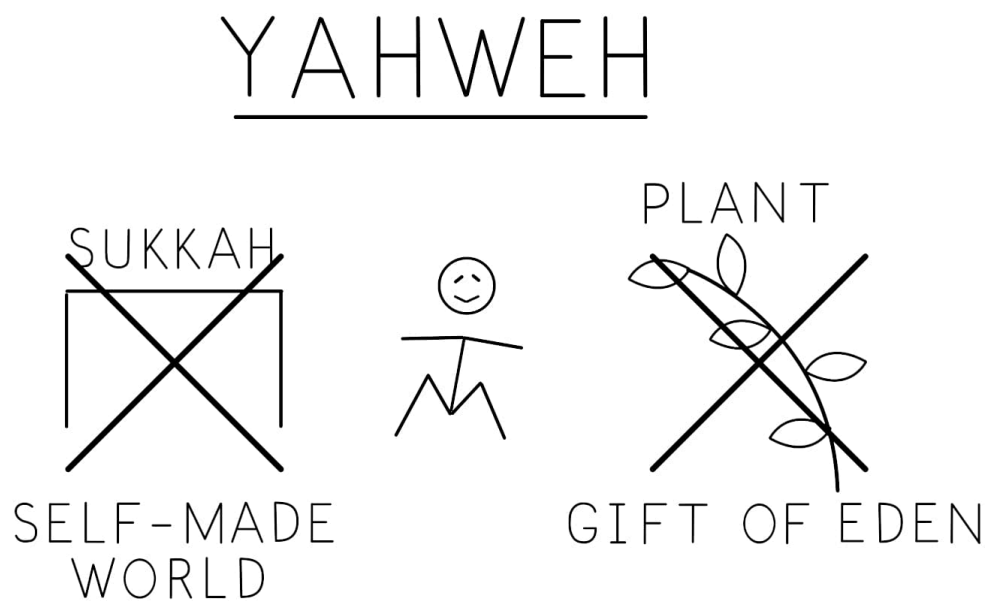


Session 44: God's Pity vs. Jonah's Pity

Key Takeaways

- Jonah is a symbolic image of Israel's story. God gives them the Eden gift (vines), but when the gift is no longer appreciated, God takes it away in the form of exile.
- God's question to Jonah at the end of the book confronts the reader as well. Will we allow God's merciful and just character to grow compassion in our own hearts?

Jonah's Provision vs. God's



Jonah's Versus God's Provision. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

God Appoints a Worm to Eat the Plant

7 **And God appointed a worm**

at the rising of the dawn on the next day,
and it **struck** the **qiqayon**
and it withered.

Jonah 4:5-8. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

4:7a: The “Worm” (תולעת)

There are only two other texts in the Hebrew Bible about worms eating and causing ruin, and both are relevant hyperlinks in Jonah 4.

This phrase appears in the manna story ([Exod. 16:20](#)), where the Israelites are instructed to not gather extra manna for the next day.

Exodus 16:17, 19-20 NASB*

¹⁷ The sons of Israel gathered, some very much, and some very little ... ¹⁹ And Moses said to them, "Let no one leave any of it unto morning." ²⁰ But they did not listen to Moses, and they left from it unto morning, and it was infested with worms (תולעה).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This phrase also appears in a section of “inverted-Eden” curses that will come upon the land because of Israel’s obedience ([Deut. 28:39](#)).

Deuteronomy 28:38-39 NASB*

³⁸ “You will bring much seed out to the field, but you will gather little, for the locust will eat it away. ³⁹ You will plant vineyards, and work them, but you will drink no wine and you will not gather, for the worm (תולעת) will eat it.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In both of these texts, the worms are sent by God to reverse an Eden blessing. In [Exodus 16](#), the manna is called “the bread from the heavens” ([Exod. 16:4](#)), and in [Deuteronomy 28](#), the blessings are all Eden-like and abundant. And the worms are the result of being exiled out of Eden, where animals become hostile instead of peaceable with humans. Worms are also associated with death and decomposing corpses ([Isa. 14:11](#), [66:24](#)), so they are the ultimate icon of post-Eden mortality and loss. In this way, the worm is a much more clear instrument of divine judgment than the fish, which plays a more positive role both in [Genesis 1](#) (day 5 of creation) and here in this story.

The Withered Vine

The image of a healthy growing vine that quickly withers as a sign of God’s judgment is a common motif in the Prophets for rulers and their kingdoms that grow and quickly pass away.

Isaiah 40:6-7, 23-24 Instructor’s Translation

⁶ All flesh is grass, and all its covenant loyalty like a flower of the field.

⁷ The grass withers and the flower fades,
for the wind of Yahweh blows upon it ...

²³ He makes rulers into nothing,
and makes the judges of the land like nothingness.

²⁴ Scarcely are they planted,
scarcely do they take root, their stock in the ground,
and then he blows on them and they wither,
and a storm lifts them away like chaff.

Israel's monarchy is likened to a flourishing vine that is blown by the east wind so that it withers.

Ezekiel 17:2-10 NASB

² Son of man, propound a riddle and speak a parable to the house of Israel ... ⁵ [an eagle] took some of the seed of the land and planted it in fertile soil. He placed it beside abundant waters; he set it as a willow. ⁶ Then it sprouted and became a low, spreading vine with its branches turned toward him, but its roots remained under it. So it became a vine and yielded shoots and sent out branches. ... ¹⁰ Behold, though it is planted, will it thrive? Will it not completely wither as soon as the east wind reaches it—wither on the beds where it grew?

Ezekiel 19:10-12 NASB

¹⁰ Your mother was like a vine in your vineyard,
planted by the waters;
it was fruitful and full of branches
because of abundant waters.
¹¹ And it had strong branches fit for scepters of rulers,
and its height was raised above the clouds
so that it was seen in its height with the mass of its branches.
¹² But it was plucked up in fury;
it was cast down to the ground;
and the east wind dried up its fruit.
Its strong branch was torn off,
so that it withered

See also [Psalm 80](#); [Isaiah 5:1-7](#); [Hosea 10](#); [Joel 1:12-20](#)

If Jonah's joy over his vine and his subsequent loss of it is a parable to teach him about God's mercy, the royal associations with a ruined vine point toward Israel's history. Just as God provided the line of David for Israel (out of nowhere, like the vine), so too will he take it away (exile).

God Appoints the East Wind to Strike Jonah

No Shelter From the Sun

8 And it came about as the sun shone
and **God appointed an east wind**, a hot one,
and the sun **struck** the upon the head of Jonah.

Jonah 4:5-8. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

After Jonah made his own shelter “for shade,” God provided a superior shade, namely an Eden-like plant whose name recalls Jonah’s own rebellion and its consequences (“vomit”), which have continued to this moment. God continues to muster the forces of creation to bring Jonah to a similar posture of repentance as the king of Nineveh. So God takes the plant away so that Jonah is exposed to the hot wind and the heat of the sun.

Notice that the east wind and the sun are distinct elements in this scene, and while the function of the sun is clear (it strikes Jonah’s head), the purpose or result of the east wind is not mentioned.

Sasson (*Jonah*, 304) notes that the east wind does not kill the plant (the worm did that), nor is it associated with the heat (the sun is). Given all of the associations of the east wind with acts of divine judgment (see below), it makes most sense that the purpose of the east wind is to sweep away Jonah’s shelter, leaving him open to the bright heat of the sun in the following sentence.

The “east wind” has ominous associations of divine judgment that are drawn upon here.

- Famine is caused by the east wind (*Gen. 41:6*)
- The locusts are brought to Egypt by an east wind (*Exod. 10:13*)
- God sends an east wind to part the waters (salvation) and destroy the Egyptians (judgment) (*Exod. 14:21*)
- Israel’s scattering to Babylonian exile is metaphorically caused by the east wind (*Jer. 18:16*)
- The line of David is like a vine withered by the east wind and carried to Babylon (*Ezek. 17:10; 19:12*)
- The ships of Tarshish are broken by the east wind (*Ezek. 27:26; Psalm 48:7*)

“An East *Harishit* Wind”

The word חרישית occurs only here in ancient Hebrew. Its root ח.ר.ש could mean “silent” or “plow.” It is likely that the word was chosen on the basis of a network of wordplay with various intertexts.

- Elijah’s experience of God’s “silence” after the wind on Mount Sinai (*1 Kgs. 19:11-12*)
- God’s “wind” that appears “in the beginning” (בראשית // חרישית *Gen. 1:2*)
- The consonants ח/ר/ש are densely packed in *Jonah 4:6-8*

“The Sun Struck Jonah’s Head”

This phrase appears twice elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible, *Isaiah 49:10* and *Psalm 121:6*. Both are relevant to *Jonah 4*.

Psalm 121 is a poem where Yahweh’s role as deliverer is described with images rich with association with Jonah.

Psalm 121:5-7 NASB*

⁵ Yahweh is your keeper [unlike Cain!];

Yahweh is your shade on your right hand [contrast Jonah's self-made shade-shelter!].

⁶ The sun will not strike you by day [contrast Jonah's "beating" from the sun],
nor the moon by night.

⁷ Yahweh will keep you from all evil [unlike Jonah's "evil" that he can't escape!];
he will keep your soul.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 49:10, within the context of [Isaiah 49:8-13](#), details how the newly appointed servant will lead the exiles out of prison/darkness and into a restored Eden by way of the wilderness. On that journey, the sun will not strike them as God provides pools of water as they journey home.

Jonah's Second Death Wish and God's Second Question

This second dialogue has been designed on the model of the first dialogue in 4:3-4a, but this round intensifies the conflict between Jonah and God, especially after the loss of the shelter and the heat of the sun.

Round One: 4:3-4a

Jonah and God Dialogue

- B
- a ³ And now, Yahweh, please **take my life from** me,
 - b for **good is my** **dying** **more than my living** .
 - c ⁴ **And Yahweh said, "Is it good that there is heat-anger to you?"** "

Jonah 4:1-11. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Round Two: 4:8-9

Jonah and God Dialogue

- B'
- a And he fainted, and he **requested his life** , to **die** ,
 - b and he said, "**Good is my** **dying** **more than my living** ."
 - c ⁹ And God said to Jonah, "Is it good that there is heat-anger to you over this qiqayon?"
 - b' And he said, "**It is good** **that there is heat-anger to me** , **unto** **death** !"

Jonah 4:1-11. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Key Hyperlinks

Jonah's fate east of Nineveh is likened again to Israel in the wilderness.

Exodus 14:11-12 NASB

¹¹ Then they said to Moses, "Is it because there were no graves in Egypt that you have taken us away to die in the wilderness? Why have you dealt with us in this way, bringing us out of Egypt? ¹² Is this not the word that we spoke to you in Egypt, saying, 'Leave us alone that we may serve the Egyptians'? For it would have been better for us to serve the Egyptians than to die in the wilderness."

Exodus 16:3 NASB

The sons of Israel said to them, "If only we had died by the LORD's hand in the land of Egypt, when we sat by the pots of meat, when we ate bread to the full; for you have brought us out into this wilderness to kill this whole assembly with hunger."

Numbers 14:2-3 NASB*

² All the sons of Israel grumbled against Moses and Aaron; and the whole congregation said to them, "If only we had died in the land of Egypt! Or would that we had died in this wilderness! ³ Why is the LORD bringing us into this land, to fall by the sword? Our wives and our little ones will become plunder; would it not be better for us to return to Egypt?"

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In all of these narratives, the Israelites' desire for death appears irrational and the result of self-delusion. This response shows the ultimate lack of trust defiance of the creative power of Yahweh.

The second dialogue creates a more explicit analogy between Jonah and Elijah in [1 Kings 19](#), both of which activate hyperlinks to two stages of Moses' leadership of Israel.

Noble Moses on Mount Sinai

Exodus 32:30-32 NASB

³⁰ On the next day Moses said to the people, "You yourselves have committed a great sin; and now I am going up to the LORD, perhaps I can make atonement for your sin." ³¹ Then Moses returned to the LORD, and said, "Alas, this people has committed a great sin, and they have made a god of gold for themselves. ³² But now, if you will, forgive their sin— and if not, please blot me out from your book which you have written!"

Disillusioned Moses in the Wilderness

Numbers 11:11, 14-15 NASB

¹¹ So Moses said to the LORD, "Why have you done evil to your servant? And why have I not found favor in your sight, that you have laid the burden of all this people on me? ... ¹⁴ I alone am not able to carry all this people, because it is too burdensome for me. ¹⁵ So if you are going to deal thus with me, please kill me at once, if I have found favor in your sight, and do not let me see my wretchedness."

1 Kings 19: Elijah	Jonah 1-4
Elijah flees from Jezebel after defeating the prophets of Baal on Mt. Carmel	Jonah flees from God's call to go to Nineveh
Elijah walks one day into the wilderness (19:4a)	Jonah walks one day into Nineveh (3:4) Jonah goes east of Nineveh (4:5)
Elijah "asked for his life, to die (וישאל את־נפשו למות)" (19:4b)	"And now, Yahweh, please take my life (נפשי) from me, for good is my death more than my life" (4:3) "And he asked for his life, to die (וישאל את־נפשו למות)" (4:8)
"And he lay down and he slept (וישכב ויישן), and look, an angel touching him, and he said, 'Arise (קום), eat!'" (19:5)	"And [Jonah] lay down and he slept (וישכב וירדם) ... And the captain said ... 'Arise (קום) call on your God!'" (1:5-6)
Elijah journeys 40 days to Mt. Horeb (Mount Sinai) (19:8)	Jonah announces 40 days until Nineveh's destruction (3:4)
God asks Elijah two times why he has come to Mt. Horeb (19:9, 13)	God asks two times if it is good that Jonah is angry at his mercy (4:4, 9)
Elijah gives the same exaggerated, self-pitying answer two times (19:10, 14)	Jonah gives the same pathetic and selfish answer two times (4:2, 9)
God communicates with Elijah through symbolic natural phenomena (wind, earthquake, lightning) (19:11-12)	God communicates with Jonah through symbolic natural phenomena (plant, worm, wind) (4:6-8)
God counters Elijah's self-pity: You are not the only faithful Israelite, I have 7,000 others (19:18)	God counters Jonah's self-pity: You had pity on this plant, shouldn't I have pity on a great city? (4:10-11)
Narrative Analogy Between Elijah and Jonah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).	

Reflections on the Jonah/Elijah Analogy

The large-scale comparison with Elijah is crucial to the portrayal of Jonah's character. Both prophets played their role in communicating the divine word. (Elijah did so willingly, Jonah not so willingly). However, both prophets fundamentally misunderstand the bigger picture of God's purpose, and they respond in a self-oriented way.

Neither prophet takes it upon themselves to intercede for Israel the way Abraham did for Sodom or as Moses did for Israel. Neither prophet can see beyond their own life circumstances, despite the fact that God patiently invites them into a conversation (two times!).

Both prophets invert the Moses model of the prophet who offers his own life in the place of God's enemies. They would rather die for their tiny narrative instead of giving their life for God's larger purposes in the world. Both prophets seek Eden-like shelters in order to evade their real responsibilities.

God's Final Question for Jonah: Translation and Literary Design of Jonah 4:10-11

A	10 And Yahweh said, "You had pity
B	over this qiqayon ,
C	which you did not labor for it, nor did you make it great, which a son of the night it was, and a son of the night it perished.
A'	11 And shouldn't I have pity
B'	over Nineveh , the great city,
C'	which there is in it more than twelve ten-thousand humans, who don't know between their right and their left, and many animals?

Jonah 4:10-11. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

God's purpose in the vine is to create a parable-like experience for Jonah so that his pity for the plant is likened to God's pity on the nations, embodied in the iconic evil city of Nineveh.

- Jonah's pity = God's pity
- The plant = Nineveh the great city
- The plant's greatness = Nineveh's greatness

These comparisons between Nineveh and the plant provided by God are connected to a series of hyperlinked texts.

The Plant and the City

God's emphasis that Jonah did not labor (עמל) for the plant or make it great (גדול) recalls a key motif in the Torah and Prophets that the abundance of the promised land was not the result of Israel's power or labor.

Deuteronomy 6:10-11 NASB

¹⁰ "Then it shall come about when the LORD your God brings you into the land which he swore to your fathers, Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, to give you, great and good cities which you did not build, ¹¹ and houses full of all good things which you did not fill, and hewn cisterns which you did not dig, vineyards and olive trees which you did not plant, and you eat and are satisfied,

Joshua 24:13 NASB

I gave you a land on which you had not labored, and cities which you had not built, and you have lived in them; you are eating of vineyards and olive groves which you did not plant.

120,000 Humans

Verse 11 ("more than 120,000 humans") is worded in a strange way in Hebrew. The normal phrase would be "one hundred and twenty-thousand" (אלף ועשרים מאה) (see [Jdg. 8:10](#); [1 Kgs. 8:63](#)). But in Jonah 4:11, we find "twelve ten-thousands (רבו עשרה שטים). This is the only time 120,000 is phrased this way in the Hebrew Bible. This way of expressing the number highlights the number twelve.

In Genesis, when God chooses a certain lineage extending from Abraham (Isaac and then Jacob), God promises to also give his blessing to the non-chosen line of Ishmael.

Of Ishmael, God says "I will make him a great nation" ([Gen. 16:18](#)), "I will make him fruitful and multiply, and he will be the father of twelve rulers and a great nation." In Genesis 25:12-16, Ishmael's descendants have "twelve tribal rulers" ([Gen. 25:16](#)).

It's likely that in Jonah 4:11, the author is presenting Nineveh "the great city" as yet another divinely blessed nation consisting of "twelve ten-thousands" and therefore equally worthy of his attention and mercy.

Who Don't Know Right from Left

In Hebrew, the word "human" is singular (אדם *adam*), which evokes the *adam* / humanity figure from Genesis chapters 1-3. The depiction of *adam* not having access to true knowledge is a key motif in the role of the tree of knowing good and evil in [Genesis 2:9](#) and [Genesis 2:15-16](#).

To "go/turn right or left" is a turn of phrase in Hebrew that means to know the straight, or correct, way. It can be used literally as people go on a journey ([Gen. 24:49](#); [Num. 20:17](#)), or metaphorically where "right or left" is the opposite of the straight path that is morally good ([Deut. 5:32](#), [17:11](#)).

“To know between good and evil” is a key phrase used in divine wisdom texts built on the design pattern from Genesis 2-3. The phrase refers to moral discernment, the ability to discriminate between the morally good and beneficial and the morally bad and harmful. This is a trait connected with moral maturity.

Deuteronomy 1:39 NASB*

Your little ones ... and your sons, who today do not know good or evil, shall enter there, and I will give it to them and they shall possess it.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 7:15-16 NASB

¹⁵ [Immanuel] will eat curds and honey at the time he knows to refuse evil and choose good. ¹⁶ For before the boy will know to refuse evil and choose good, the land whose two kings you dread will be forsaken.

1 Kings 3:7, 9 NASB*

⁷ Now, O LORD my God, you have made your servant king in place of my father David, yet I am but a little child; I do not know how to go out or come in. ... ⁹ So give your servant a heart that listens, to judge your people, to discern between good and evil. For who is able to judge this great people of yours?

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This was the knowledge of good and evil that Adam and Eve took on their own terms instead of learning it from God (as Solomon did, see 1 Kgs. 3:9 above). This was the divine wisdom given to Israel in the Torah, which taught moral discernment about good and evil, which is also associated with the phrase “right and left.”

Torah Teaches “Right and Left”

Deuteronomy 5:32-33 NASB

³² So you shall observe to do just as the LORD your God has commanded you; you shall not turn aside to the right or to the left. ³³ You shall walk in all the way which the LORD your God has commanded you, that you may live and that it may be good with you, and that you may live long days in the land which you will possess.

Deuteronomy 17:11, 19-20 NASB*

¹¹ According to the terms of the Torah which [the priests] teach you, and according to the verdict which they tell you, you shall do; you shall not turn aside from the word which they declare to you, to the right or the left. ... ¹⁹ [the Torah] shall be with him and he shall read it all the days of his life, that he may learn to fear the LORD his God, by carefully observing all the words of this law and these statutes, ²⁰ that his heart may not be lifted up above his countrymen and that he may not turn aside from the commandment, to the right or the left, so that he and his sons may live long in his kingdom in the midst of Israel.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Deuteronomy 28:11-14 NASB*

¹¹ The LORD will make you abound in goodness ... in the land which the LORD swore to your fathers to give you. ¹² The LORD will open for you his storehouse of the good ... ¹³ if you listen to the commandments of the LORD your God, which I charge you today, to observe them carefully, ¹⁴ do not turn aside from any of the words which I command you today, to the right or to the left ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Joshua 1:7 NASB*

be strong and very courageous; be careful to do according to all the Torah which Moses my servant commanded you; do not turn from it to the right or to the left

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Torah Teaches “Good and Evil”

Deuteronomy 30:9-10, 15-16 NASB*

⁹ Then the LORD your God will prosper you abundantly in all the work of your hand, in the offspring of your body and in the offspring of your cattle and in the produce of your ground, for the LORD will again rejoice over you for good, just as he rejoiced over your fathers. ¹⁰ If you obey the LORD your God to keep his commandments and his statutes which are written in this scroll of the Torah ... ¹⁵ “See, I have set before you today life and good, and death and evil; ¹⁶ in that I command you today to love the LORD your God, to walk in his ways and to keep his commandments and his statutes and his judgments, that you may live and multiply, and that the LORD your God may bless you in the land where you are entering to possess it.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In the theology of the Torah, the true way to wisdom and discernment between good and evil is found in the Torah, which teaches us how to go straight and not to the “right and left.” The Torah was Israel’s source of wisdom, which was not given to any other nation.

Conclusions About “Knowing Between Right and Left” in Jonah 4:11

Jonah 4:11 has merged the phrases “know between good and evil” with “no turning to the right or left” so that the pagan nations are characterized as those who haven’t been given the special revelation into God’s will that Israel has. And this is precisely what makes the nations the objects of God’s mercy.

Reflection Question

Based on [chapter 4](#) and the ending of Jonah, how do you think the author wants the audience to respond to the book? How can you help those in your context have this same response?

Session 45: Reflecting on the Ending of Jonah

Key Takeaways

- The mercy of God is remarkable. It is given to our enemies and also to us when we struggle with the fact that God loves our enemies.
- The meaning of Jonah is clear, and we can all agree on it no matter our different views about the historical reference of the events in the book.

The Sense of an Ending

“The narrative of Jonah’s story lacks closure, a sense of completion, and a sense that nothing necessary has been omitted from the work. The book ends without a resolution to the major conflict of the narrative’s plot. The reader experiences the greatest sense of closure at the end of the third chapter as Nineveh repents and God forgives. Even the fourth chapter begins by providing closure regarding Jonah’s flight, but the book’s final scene immediately reopens that closure just experienced by the reader. God’s question concludes the book, leaving Jonah’s response in the minds of the reader. This lack of closure at the end of the narrative is a literary device used to involve the reader in the ideological conflict that propels the real plot of the book: Jonah’s sense of justice versus God’s boundless mercy. The final scene blurs the narrative frame, so that the world of the text reaches out and envelops the world of the reader, forcing them to ask whose perspective they will adopt.”

Crouch, Walter B. (1994). “To Question and End, To End and Question: Opening and Closure in the Book of Jonah.” *Sage Journals*, vol. 19, 62. 112.

“[T]he final scene is so skillfully designed that when Jonah insists on Yahweh’s free pity, he cannot really avoid simultaneously conceding to his God the forgiving mercy he has extended to the pagans. But the narrator leaves the readers to draw this harmonizing conclusion themselves. Even the most morosely obstinate of them can hardly do other than—in Jonah’s place—respond with gratitude to their God’s final question.”

Wolff, Hans Walter (1986). [*Obadiah and Jonah: A Commentary*](#). Augsburg Fortress. 88.

“The ‘surprise’ gap at the beginning of the story, with regard to Jonah’s motive for running away, is filled in at the conclusion, when Jonah impeaches the Lord’s grace and compassion as the reason for his flight (4:2), and even more so in the last verse of the book, in which the Lord justifies His decision to show mercy for Nineveh. As Meir Sternberg argues, the impression conveyed by the start of the story is that God is wrathful and punitive. As for Jonah and his flight, we mistakenly believe that the recalcitrant prophet ‘is too tenderhearted to carry a message of doom to a great city. He obviously protests against a wrathful God not with words, like Abraham or Moses or Samuel, but with his feet.’ But the last verses of the book show that we had it backwards: Jonah does not flee because God is a wrathful God, but because He is a merciful God.

The Lord's reaction to the Ninevites' penance—"When God saw what they did, how they turned from their evil way, God repented of the evil which He had said he would do to them; and He did not do it" (3:10)—clearly echoes 'the Lord repented of the evil which he thought to do to his people' (Exod 32:14). Thus the book of Jonah teaches us that the Lord's mercy is not reserved exclusively for 'His people' but extends to all of His creation, including its animals, who (unlike Jonah) are not only obedient agents of his will in this story, but also, along with humans, objects of his mercy."

Shemesh, Yael (2010). "'And Many Beasts' (Jonah 4:11): The Function and Status of Animals in the Book of Jonah." *Journal of Hebrew Scriptures*, vol. 10. 22

You, Jonah,
how low
how deep
will you go
to secure
sleep?

You, Jonah,
how high
will you fare
hoping I
will ignore
you there?

You, Jonah,
how far
will you aim
your mariner
to protect your name
from my claim?

You! Jonah!

And Jonah stalked
to his shaded seat
and waited for God
to come around
to his way of thinking.
And God is still waiting
for a host of Jonahs
in their comfortable houses
to come around
to his way of loving.

Carlisle, Thomas John (1968). [*You! Jonah!*](#) Eerdmans.

Reflection Question

As you ponder the end of Jonah, why do you think the book ends with a question?